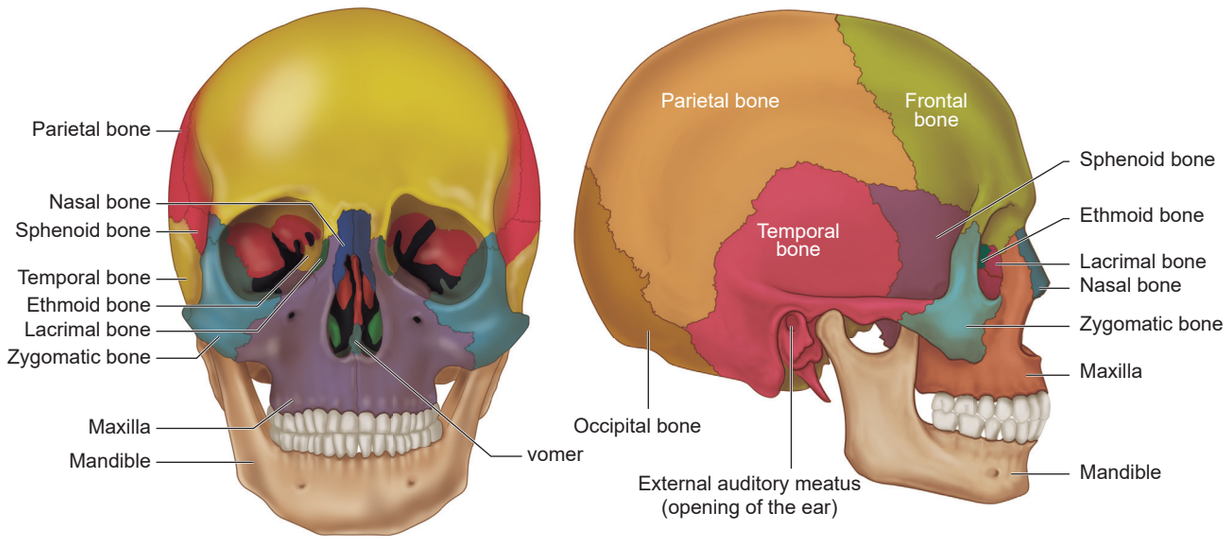


Figure 9. 5 Structure of the skull

The large hole in the temporal bone is the **external auditory meatus**. In the facial bones **maxilla, zygomatic, palatine, lacrimal, nasal, inferior nasal concha** are paired bones whereas **mandible** or **lower jaw** and **vomer** are **unpaired bones**. They form the front part of the skull. A single U-shaped **hyoid bone** is present at the base of the buccal cavity. It is the only one bone without any joint. Each middle ear contains three tiny bones- **malleus**, **incus** and **stapes** collectively are called **ear ossicles**. The upper jaw is formed of the **maxilla** and the lower jaw is formed of the **mandible**. The upper jaw is fused with the cranium and is immovable. The lower jaw is connected to the cranium by muscles and is movable. The most prominent openings in the skull are **the orbits** and **the nasal cavity**. **Foramen magnum** is a large opening found at the posterior base of the skull**.** Through this opening the medulla oblongata of the brain descends down as the spinal cord.

b) The Vertebral Column

Vertebral column is also called the back bone. It consists of 33 serially arranged vertebrae which are interconnected by cartilage known as intervertebral disc (Figure 9.6). The vertebral column extends from the base of the skull to the pelvis and forms the main frame work of the trunk. The vertebral column has five major regions. They are, **the Cervical**, **Thoracic**, **Lumbar**, **Sacrum** (5 sacral vertebrae found in the infant which are fused to form one bone in the adult) and

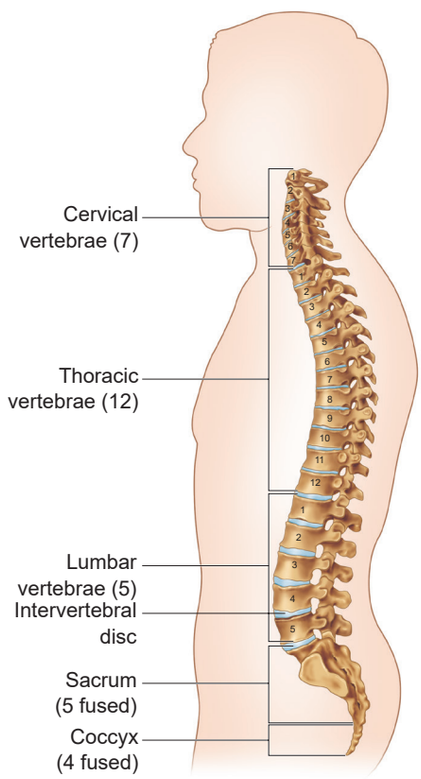


Figure 9. 6 Vertebral Column

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